

Core Narrative Transportation and Persuasion Literature for a PhD

Executive summary

The literature on narrative transportation, immersion, and persuasion converges on a relatively stable set of **text-side antecedents** and **reader-side antecedents**. On the text side, the strongest recurring candidates are **verisimilitude and perceived realism, narrative consistency/coherence, identifiable characters, imaginable plot, point of view/perspective, and emotionally involving story structure**. On the reader side, the most consistent candidates are **transportability, need for affect, need for cognition, prior knowledge/familiarity, trait empathy, sensation seeking, and perceived protagonist similarity/self-referencing**. Meta-analytic work indicates that storyteller-side antecedents such as identifiable characters, imaginable plot, and verisimilitude are positively related to transportation, while story-receiver antecedents such as familiarity, attention, and transportability are likewise positively associated with transportation; transportation then predicts affective response, lower critical thought, and stronger story-consistent beliefs, attitudes, and intentions. ¹

For a PhD without domain constraints, the most defensible starting model is a **two-level framework**. Level one is the narrative stimulus: realism, coherence, causality, character design, focalization, emotional intensity, and imagery affordance. Level two is the reader: transportability, affective orientation, cognitive orientation, familiarity, empathy, sensation seeking, similarity perceptions, and self-referencing propensity. This structure is both theoretically grounded and operationally tractable, because most variables already have validated scales or clear coding strategies in the core literature. ²

The two most important methodological takeaways for study design are these. First, **narrative persuasion rarely depends on a single feature**; it is usually an interaction among story features, transportation/identification processes, and reader predispositions. Second, several highly cited studies show that superficially intuitive variables such as demographic similarity do **not** always work directly; perceived similarity, self-referencing, or perspective-taking often matter more than crude demographic matching. ³

Scope and selection logic

I prioritized English-language articles that are either **seminal empirical studies, high-impact theoretical articles, meta-analyses, or influential reviews** directly relevant to narrative transportation/immersion/persuasion. In practice, that meant weighting three criteria together: direct relevance to your categories, citation footprint, and usefulness for variable construction. Where Google Scholar item-level counts were visible in search results, I report them as such; where they were not visible, I note either an alternate count from another reputable source or mark the value as unspecified. Because several foundational papers bridge both categories, a few articles appear conceptually in both syntheses. ⁴

Core articles on narrative text features

Green, M. C., & Brock, T. C. (2000). *The role of transportation in the persuasiveness of public narratives*. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 79(5), 701–721. DOI: [10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.701](https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.701). Citation count: Google Scholar item-level count not exposed in retrieved result; alternate web counts visible were 4,719 on ResearchGate and 7,919 “cited by” on PubMed/Europe PMC. This is the field-defining article for transportation as a mechanism of persuasion. It defines transportation as a convergent state involving imagery, affect, and attentional focus, develops a transportation scale, and reports two experiments in which higher transportation increased story-consistent beliefs and favorable evaluations of protagonists, while also making readers less likely to notice “false notes” in the story. Its relevance for text features is foundational: it establishes why features that increase absorption, imagery, and attentional focus are theoretically consequential for persuasion. OA/PDF availability: author-hosted PDF visible in search results. ⁵

Slater, M. D., & Rouner, D. (2002). *Entertainment-education and elaboration likelihood: Understanding the processing of narrative persuasion*. *Communication Theory*, 12(2), 173–191. DOI: [10.1111/j.1468-2885.2002.tb00265.x](https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2885.2002.tb00265.x) (publisher pages also expose an OUP article path). Citation count: about 2,638 in retrieved search results. This article is one of the major theoretical bridges between persuasion theory and narrative processing. It argues that narrative processing, especially absorption into storylines and characters, can suppress counterarguing and reduce the usual role of topic involvement in persuasion, which is especially important for counterattitudinal content. For your PhD, it is crucial because it treats features such as story format, character-centered involvement, and immersive structure not as decorative elements but as design variables that change the processing route itself. OA/PDF availability: PDF result visible in search results. ⁶

Green, M. C. (2004). *Transportation into narrative worlds: The role of prior knowledge and perceived realism*. *Discourse Processes*, 38(2), 247–266. DOI: [10.1207/s15326950dp3802_5](https://doi.org/10.1207/s15326950dp3802_5). Citation count: about 1,588 in retrieved search results. In this study, undergraduates read a story about a gay man returning to a fraternity reunion and then rated transportation, perceived realism, and story-relevant beliefs. The article reports that transportation was positively correlated with perceived realism, and secondary summaries indicate that prior knowledge or experience relevant to the topic and genre increased transportation. It is especially relevant because it directly elevates **realism** and **topic/genre knowledge** into core antecedents of transportation, making realism one of the most defensible text variables in your eventual model. DOI available; abstract and metadata were visible in multiple search results. ⁷

Busselle, R., & Bilandzic, H. (2008). *Fictionality and perceived realism in experiencing stories: A model of narrative comprehension and engagement*. *Communication Theory*, 18(2), 255–280. DOI: [10.1111/j.1468-2885.2008.00322.x](https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2885.2008.00322.x). Citation count: about 1,393–1,394 in retrieved search results. This highly influential theoretical article proposes a mental-model account of how audiences process narratives and explains when perceived “unrealness” disrupts engagement. Its key contribution is to distinguish sources of realism problems, including inconsistency with the real world, inconsistency with genre expectations, and incoherence within the story world itself. For your project, it strongly supports coding **external realism**, **genre verisimilitude**, and **narrative consistency/coherence** as separate but related text features likely to affect immersion and persuasion. OA/PDF availability: postprint visible in the University of Augsburg repository. ⁸

Moyer-Gusé, E. (2008). *Toward a theory of entertainment persuasion: Explaining the persuasive effects of entertainment-education messages*. Communication Theory, 18(3), 407–425. DOI: 10.1111/j.1468-2885.2008.00328.x . Citation count: about 2,225 in retrieved search results. This major theoretical paper synthesizes entertainment-education research and clarifies related constructs such as identification, parasocial interaction, similarity, and transportation. The article's lasting value is that it treats narrative persuasion as a function of **storyline involvement, character involvement**, and reduced resistance, rather than merely exposure to message content. For your purposes, it is especially useful for distinguishing which text features operate mainly through **character pathways** and which operate through **plot/storyline pathways**. DOI available; abstract was retrievable from the publisher page. 9

Busselle, R., & Bilandzic, H. (2009). *Measuring narrative engagement*. Media Psychology, 12(4), 321–347. DOI: 10.1080/15213260903287259 . Citation count: about 1,920–1,921 in retrieved search results. This article develops one of the core measures used across narrative immersion research. Building on the mental-models framework, it distinguishes four dimensions of experiential engagement: narrative understanding, attentional focus, emotional engagement, and narrative presence. It is indispensable for a PhD because it gives you a more granular operationalization of immersion than a single global transportation score and implicitly points to the kinds of text features that should drive each dimension differently. OA/PDF availability: repository PDF visible in search results. 10

de Graaf, A., Hoeken, H., Sanders, J., & Beentjes, J. W. J. (2012). *Identification as a mechanism of narrative persuasion*. Communication Research, 39(6), 802–823. DOI: 10.1177/0093650211408594 . Citation count: about 882–885 in retrieved search results. This article offers a causal test of identification by experimentally manipulating the perspective from which a story is told. In Experiment 1, 120 participants read a story told from the perspective of one of two characters with opposing goals; story perspective influenced identification and the consistency of attitudes with the focal character's position. It is central for text-feature work because it shows that **narrative perspective/focalization** is not a cosmetic stylistic choice; it changes identification and downstream persuasion. 11

Escalas, J. E. (2007). *Self-referencing and persuasion: Narrative transportation versus analytical elaboration*. Journal of Consumer Research, 33(4), 421–429. DOI: 10.1086/510216 . Citation count: about 1,198–1,208 in retrieved search results. This article is important because it explicitly contrasts two routes to persuasion: narrative transportation and analytical elaboration, both framed as forms of self-referencing. Although the retrieved abstract snippets exposed less methodological detail than for some other papers, the article is widely cited for showing that narrative forms can induce a different kind of self-connection than analytic message formats. In practical terms, it justifies operationalizing features such as **episodic storytelling, self-relevance cues**, and **simulation-promoting language** rather than treating self-reference as a purely reader-side trait. DOI available from the Journal of Consumer Research page. 12

Cho, H., Shen, L., & Wilson, K. (2014). *Perceived realism: Dimensions and roles in narrative persuasion*. Communication Research, 41(6), 828–851. DOI: 10.1177/0093650212450585 . Citation count: about 400 in retrieved search results. This study is one of the strongest direct articles on realism as a text feature. Across responses to messages on three topics, it found that perceived realism is multidimensional, comprising plausibility, typicality, factuality, narrative consistency, and perceptual quality; plausibility predicted emotional involvement, typicality predicted identification, and narrative consistency/perceptual quality predicted message evaluation, with all three mediators predicting attitudes. For a PhD, this paper is invaluable because it breaks “realism” into measurable subdimensions instead of leaving it as one vague variable. 13

van Laer, T., de Ruyter, K., Visconti, L. M., & Wetzels, M. (2014). *The Extended Transportation-Imagery Model: A meta-analysis of the antecedents and consequences of consumers' narrative transportation*. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 40(5), 797–817. DOI: journal DOI not clearly exposed in retrieved snippets; accepted-manuscript SSRN abstract and repository PDF were visible. Citation count: about 1,786 in retrieved search results. This is the highest-value quantitative synthesis for your PhD because it aggregates 76 papers and 132 effect sizes. On the storyteller side, it reports positive reliability-adjusted associations between transportation and **identifiable characters** ($\rho \approx .20$), **imaginable plot** ($\rho \approx .29$), and **verisimilitude** ($\rho \approx .27$). It therefore provides the clearest empirical justification for treating those three text variables as the initial core of a narrative-feature model. OA/PDF availability: accepted manuscript visible in City Research Online. ¹⁴

Core articles on reader individual differences

Mazzocco, P. J., Green, M. C., Sasota, J. A., & Jones, N. W. (2010). *This story is not for everyone: Transportability and narrative persuasion*. *Social Psychological and Personality Science*, 1(4), 361–368. DOI: 10.1177/1948550610376600 . Citation count: about 425 on a retrieved Google Scholar author page; publisher search pages showed about 454. Across two studies, this paper examined **transportability**—the tendency to become transported into narratives—as an individual-difference predictor of persuasion. In Study 1 (N = 137), participants were persuaded by a story promoting tolerance toward homosexuals only insofar as they were high in self-rated transportability; Study 2 (N = 298) replicated the pattern using affirmative action. This is arguably the single most important reader-differences paper for your PhD because it converts transportation from a state-only construct into a dispositional moderator. ¹⁵

Appel, M., & Richter, T. (2010). *Transportation and need for affect in narrative persuasion: A mediated moderation model*. *Media Psychology*, 13(2), 101–135. DOI: 10.1080/15213261003799847 . Citation count: about 624–629 in retrieved Google Scholar snippets. This article provides one of the clearest mechanistic demonstrations of a reader trait influencing narrative persuasion. Across two experiments (combined N = 314), need for affect moderated persuasive effects of a narrative, and this moderation was itself mediated by transportation; in Experiment 1, the indirect effect was significant by Sobel test ($z = 2.47$), and in Experiment 2 it again remained significant ($z = 2.02$). For your PhD, it strongly supports including **need for affect** as a core reader variable, especially when narrative emotionality varies. OA/PDF availability: author PDF visible. ¹⁶

Zwarun, L., & Hall, A. (2012). *Narrative persuasion, transportation, and the role of need for cognition in online viewing of fantastical films*. *Media Psychology*, 15(3), 327–355. DOI: 10.1080/15213269.2012.700592 . Citation count: about 114 in retrieved search results; a ResearchGate page displayed 61 citations. This article is the most directly relevant paper linking **need for cognition** to transportation and persuasion in mediated narratives. In Study 1 (N = 160), higher transportation predicted more story-consistent privacy beliefs for one fantastical film, and higher need for cognition was associated with stronger beliefs and intentions; Study 2 (N = 126) examined distraction, suggesting that the cognitive demands of the viewing context can condition these effects. Its relevance is that it keeps cognitive-style variables on the table even in narrative contexts often treated as primarily affective. ¹⁷

Green, M. C. (2004). *Transportation into narrative worlds: The role of prior knowledge and perceived realism*. *Discourse Processes*, 38(2), 247–266. DOI: 10.1207/s15326950dp3802_5 . Citation count:

about 1,588 in retrieved search results. Although this article is also essential on the text side, it is equally important here because it treats **prior knowledge/familiarity** as a reader-side antecedent of transportation. The study used undergraduate readers (N = 152), and the retrieved abstract summaries indicate that transportation covaried positively with realism and that relevant prior knowledge/experience increased transportation. It is therefore one of the best classic sources for including **familiarity with topic/genre** in a reader-differences model. 7

van Laer, T., de Ruyter, K., Visconti, L. M., & Wetzels, M. (2014). *The Extended Transportation-Imagery Model: A meta-analysis of the antecedents and consequences of consumers' narrative transportation*. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 40(5), 797–817. Citation count: about 1,786 in retrieved search results. On the story-receiver side, this meta-analysis reports positive associations between transportation and **familiarity** ($p \approx .21$), **attention** ($p \approx .29$), and **transportability** ($p \approx .30$); age was essentially null in the retrieved model, while education and sex showed smaller positive relations. This is one of the strongest pieces of evidence that reader variables should be modeled as distinct from narrative variables rather than collapsed into a single “engagement tendency.” It is especially useful for prioritizing which reader variables deserve inclusion when sample size is limited. 18

de Graaf, A. (2014). *The effectiveness of adaptation of the protagonist in narrative impact: Similarity influences health beliefs through self-referencing*. *Human Communication Research*, 40(1), 73–90. DOI: 10.1111/hcre.12015 . Citation count: about 230 in retrieved search results. This between-subjects experiment (N = 220) varied whether the protagonist was similar or dissimilar to participants. Readers exposed to a similar protagonist perceived themselves at greater risk and reported greater efficacy in dealing with symptoms, and these effects were mediated by **self-referencing**. The paper is especially relevant because it shows that “reader individual differences” do not always act as stable traits; some must be modeled as **reader-message fit variables**, especially similarity-triggered self-relevance. 19

Chen, M., Bell, R. A., & Taylor, L. D. (2016). *Narrator point of view and persuasion in health narratives: The role of protagonist-reader similarity, identification, and self-referencing*. *Journal of Health Communication*, 21(8), 908–918. DOI: 10.1080/10810730.2016.1177147 . Citation count: about 195 in retrieved search results. Participants aged 30 or younger were randomly assigned to a 2 × 2 design manipulating first- versus third-person point of view and similar versus dissimilar protagonist in a health narrative about caffeine overdose. Contrary to expectations, point of view did not affect identification or self-referencing, but protagonist-reader similarity directly increased identification, which then influenced severity perceptions; self-referencing directly affected susceptibility perceptions. This article is highly useful because it warns against assuming that narration style automatically matters more than reader-protagonist fit. 20

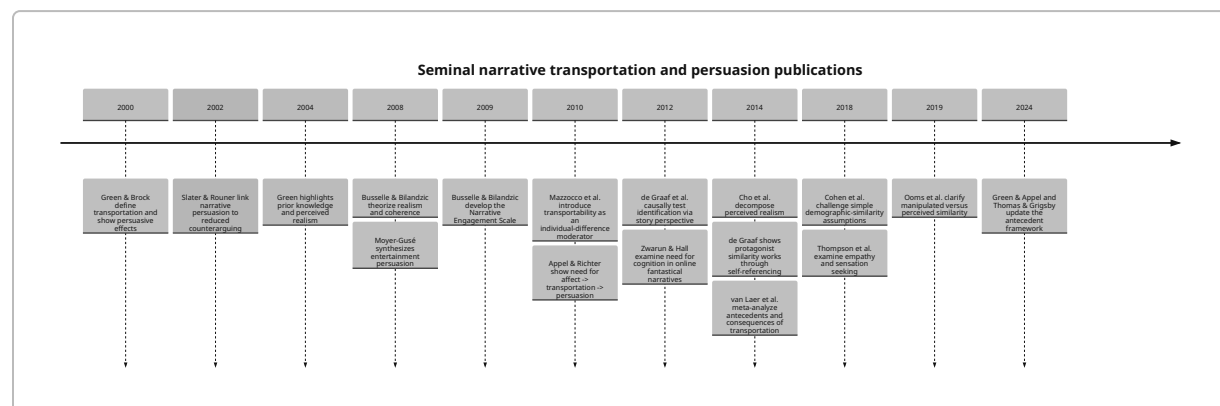
Cohen, J., Weimann-Saks, D., & Mazor-Tregerman, M. (2018). *Does character similarity increase identification and persuasion?* *Media Psychology*, 21(3), 506–528. DOI: 10.1080/15213269.2017.1302344 . Citation count: about 221 in retrieved Google Scholar snippets. This article is important because it challenges a common assumption in the literature. Across two studies, demographic similarity manipulations that should, in principle, have mattered—sex and nationality in one study, age and city of residence in another—did **not** increase perceived similarity, identification, or persuasion. The paper is therefore methodologically valuable for your PhD: it suggests that **perceived similarity** should often be measured directly rather than inferred from demographic matching. 21

Ooms, J., Hoeks, J., & Jansen, C. (2019). *“Hey, that could be me”: The role of similarity in narrative persuasion*. PLoS ONE, 14(4), e0215359. DOI: 10.1371/journal.pone.0215359 . Citation count: about 94 in retrieved Google Scholar snippets. In a large experiment (N = 582) comparing students and older adults, the authors manipulated protagonist age and gender in stories about breast versus testicular cancer. Age similarity, but not gender similarity, increased identification, transportation, and donation intention for students; for older adults, the manipulations had little effect. Structural equation modeling showed that **perceived similarity** predicted both transportation and identification, which in turn predicted attitudes and intentions. This makes Ooms et al. one of the best available studies for modeling **age similarity**, **perceived similarity**, and their interaction with audience segment. 22

Thompson, J. M., Teasdale, B., Duncan, S., van Emde Boas, E., Budelmann, F., Maguire, L., & Dunbar, R. I. M. (2018). *Individual differences in transportation into narrative drama*. Review of General Psychology, 22(2), page range not clearly exposed in retrieved snippets. DOI: 10.1037/gpr0000130 . Citation count: unspecified in retrieved Google Scholar snippets. This is the most directly targeted individual-differences article in the set. Across three studies, the authors found that celebrity worship predicted transportation in one study, while trait **sensation seeking** and **empathy** independently predicted transportation across two different film genres in another; transportation also covaried with identification and emotional response measures. Its citation count is lower than the classic persuasion papers, but its direct conceptual alignment with your reader-differences category makes it highly valuable. 23

Comparative tables and visualizations

The timeline below situates the selected literature historically, showing how the field moved from foundational transportation theory to more differentiated work on realism, identification, similarity, and meta-analysis. 24



Top articles on narrative text features

Rank	Citation	Key text features discussed	Operationalization or measures used	Sample or population	Effect sizes or main quantitative results
1	Green & Brock (2000), <i>JPSP</i> , 79(5), 701–721, DOI 10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.701 ²⁵	Transportation as imagery + affect + attentional focus; implicit text quality/ false notes	Transportation Scale; story-consistent beliefs; perceived false notes	Exp. 1 N = 97; Exp. 2 N = 69	Higher transportation increased story-consistent beliefs and favorable protagonist evaluations; highly transported readers detected fewer false notes. ²⁶
2	Slater & Rouner (2002), <i>Communication Theory</i> , 12(2), 173–191, DOI 10.1111/j.1468-2885.2002.tb00265.x ²⁷	Narrative format, storyline and character involvement, reduced counterarguing	Conceptual/ theoretical synthesis; no single common instrument	Review/theory article	No single effect size; argues that entertainment-education works partly by blocking counterarguing and shifting processing routes. ²⁸
3	Green (2004), <i>Discourse Processes</i> , 38(2), 247–266, DOI 10.1207/s15326950dp3802_5 ²⁹	Prior knowledge, perceived realism	Transportation ratings; realism ratings; story-relevant beliefs	Undergraduate readers, N = 152	Transportation positively correlated with realism; relevant prior knowledge, experience increased transportation in retrieved summaries. ³⁰

Rank	Citation	Key text features discussed	Operationalization or measures used	Sample or population	Effect sizes or main quantitative results
4	Busselle & Bilandzic (2008), <i>Communication Theory</i> , 18(2), 255–280, DOI 10.1111/j.1468-2885.2008.00322.x ³¹	External realism, genre verisimilitude, story-world coherence, deictic perspective	Theoretical mental-model framework	Theoretical/ review article	No single effect size; proposes that incoherence and unexplained unreality disrupt engagement and identification. ³²
5	Moyer-Gusé (2008), <i>Communication Theory</i> , 18(3), 407–425, DOI 10.1111/j.1468-2885.2008.00328.x ³³	Storyline involvement, character involvement, similarity, parasocial interaction	Conceptual synthesis	Theoretical/ review article	No single effect size; clarifies distinct character/ storyline mechanisms underlying entertainment persuasion. ³⁴
6	Busselle & Bilandzic (2009), <i>Media Psychology</i> , 12(4), 321–347, DOI 10.1080/15213260903287259 ³⁵	Dimensions of engagement linked to text design: understanding, attention, emotional engagement, presence	Narrative Engagement Scale	Scale-development article	No single effect size reported in retrieved abstract; provides a validated multidimensional immersion measure. ³⁶
7	de Graaf et al. (2012), <i>Communication Research</i> , 39(6), 802–823, DOI 10.1177/0093650211408594 ³⁷	Story perspective/ focalization	Experimental manipulation of character perspective; identification and attitude consistency measures	Experiment 1 N = 120; additional experiment reported in article	Perspective altered identification and story-consistent attitudes, supporting identification as a persuasive mechanism. ³⁸

Rank	Citation	Key text features discussed	Operationalization or measures used	Sample or population	Effect sizes or main quantitative results
8	Escalas (2007), <i>Journal of Consumer Research</i> , 33(4), 421–429, DOI 10.1086/510216 ³⁹	Narrative form as self-referencing route; transportation versus analytical elaboration	Self-referencing framed as transportation or elaboration	Consumer persuasion context; detailed sample/results not fully exposed in retrieved abstract snippet	Core contribution is conceptual and empirical contrast between narrative transportation and analytical elaboration as routes to persuasion. Retrieved snippet did not expose fuller statistics. ⁴⁰
9	Cho et al. (2014), <i>Communication Research</i> , 41(6), 828–851, DOI 10.1177/0093650212450585 ⁴¹	Plausibility, typicality, factuality, narrative consistency, perceptual quality	Perceived-realism dimensions; emotional involvement; identification; message evaluation; attitudes	Responses to messages on three topics	Plausibility predicted emotional involvement; typicality predicted identification; consistency and perceptual quality predicted evaluation; all predicted attitudes via mediators. ⁴²
10	van Laer et al. (2014), <i>Journal of Consumer Research</i> , 40(5), 797–817, accepted-manuscript PDF visible; journal DOI not clearly exposed in retrieved snippets ⁴³	Identifiable characters, imaginable plot, verisimilitude	Meta-analysis of transportation studies	76 papers; 132 effect sizes	Reliable positive relations with transportation for identifiable characters ($p \approx .20$), imaginable plot ($p \approx .29$), verisimilitude ($p \approx .27$). ⁴⁴

Top articles on reader individual differences

Rank	Citation	Key individual-difference variables	Measures used	Sample	Effect sizes or main results
1	Mazzocco et al. (2010), <i>Social Psychological and Personality Science</i> , 1(4), 361–368, DOI 10.1177/1948550610376600 ⁴⁵	Transportability	Self-rated transportability; topic attitudes	Study 1 N = 137; Study 2 N = 298	Persuasion emerged primarily among highly transportable readers in studies on tolerance toward homosexuals and affirmative action. ⁴⁶
2	Appel & Richter (2010), <i>Media Psychology</i> , 13(2), 101–135, DOI 10.1080/15213261003799847 ¹⁶	Need for affect	Need for Affect Questionnaire; Transportation Scale; belief measures	Two experiments, combined N = 314	Need for affect positively predicted transportation; mediated moderation supported with Sobel $z = 2.47$ in Exp. 1 and $z = 2.02$ in Exp. 2. ⁴⁷
3	Green (2004), <i>Discourse Processes</i> , 38(2), 247–266, DOI 10.1207/s15326950dp3802_5 ²⁹	Prior knowledge; familiarity	Topic-relevant knowledge/ experience; realism; transportation	Undergraduate readers, N = 152	Prior knowledge/ experience relevant to the story/topic increased transportation in retrieved summaries; transportation covaried with realism. ³⁰

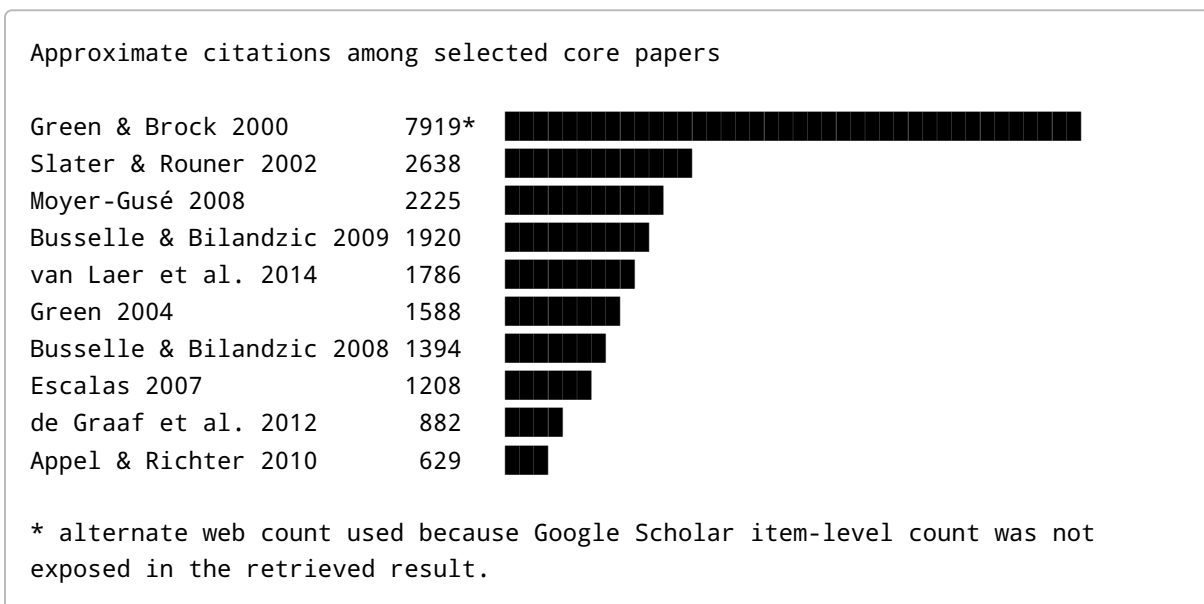
Rank	Citation	Key individual-difference variables	Measures used	Sample	Effect sizes or main results
4	van Laer et al. (2014), <i>Journal of Consumer Research</i> , 40(5), 797–817 ⁴³	Familiarity, attention, transportability, demographics	Meta-analytic aggregation across transportation studies	76 papers; 132 effect sizes	Familiarity $p \approx .21$; attention $p \approx .29$; transportability $p \approx .30$; age ≈ 0 ; smaller positive relations for education and sex in retrieved model. ⁴⁴
5	Zwarun & Hall (2012), <i>Media Psychology</i> , 15(3), 327–355, DOI 10.1080/15213269.2012.700592 ¹⁷	Need for cognition	NFC measures; transportation; beliefs; intentions; distraction manipulation	Study 1 N = 160; Study 2 N = 126	Higher NFC associated with stronger beliefs and intentions; transportation predicted privacy-consistent beliefs for one film/context. ⁴⁸
6	de Graaf (2014), <i>Human Communication Research</i> , 40(1), 73–90, DOI 10.1111/hcre.12015 ¹⁹	Protagonist similarity; self-referencing	Similar vs. dissimilar protagonist manipulation; risk/efficacy beliefs; self-referencing	Between-subjects experiment, N = 220	Similar protagonist increased perceived risk and efficacy; effects were mediated by self-referencing. ⁴⁹

Rank	Citation	Key individual-difference variables	Measures used	Sample	Effect sizes or main results
7	Chen et al. (2016), <i>Journal of Health Communication</i> , 21(8), 908–918, DOI 10.1080/10810730.2016.1177147 ⁵⁰	Protagonist–reader similarity; self-referencing	2 × 2 POV × similarity manipulation; identification; self-referencing; susceptibility/severity	Crowdsourced adults aged ≤30	POV had no effect on identification/self-referencing; similarity directly increased identification; self-referencing affected susceptibility. ⁵¹
8	Cohen et al. (2018), <i>Media Psychology</i> , 21(3), 506–528, DOI 10.1080/15213269.2017.1302344 ⁵²	Demographic similarity; perceived similarity	Manipulations of sex/nationality; age/city; identification and persuasion outcomes	Two experiments	Demographic similarity did not increase perceived similarity, identification, or persuasion in either study. ⁵³
9	Ooms et al. (2019), <i>PLOS ONE</i> , 14(4), e0215359, DOI 10.1371/journal.pone.0215359 ²²	Age similarity; gender similarity; perceived similarity	Manipulated age/gender similarity; transportation, identification, attitudes, intentions, emotions	N = 582, students and older adults	Age similarity affected identification, transportation, and donation intention for students only; perceived similarity predicted transportation and identification in SEM. ⁵⁴

Rank	Citation	Key individual-difference variables	Measures used	Sample	Effect sizes or main results
10	Thompson et al. (2018), <i>Review of General Psychology</i> , 22(2), DOI 10.1037/gpr0000130 ²³	Celebrity worship; empathy; sensation seeking	Trait measures plus transportation and response variables	Three studies; multiple film contexts	Celebrity worship predicted transportation; empathy and sensation seeking independently predicted transportation across genres. Exact standardized coefficients were not exposed in retrieved abstract. ⁵⁵

Citation-count comparison

The chart below compares the citation footprint of the most-cited papers in the selected set. Counts are **directional rather than fully bibliometric**, because some came from Google Scholar snippets while a few required fallback counts from alternate reputable sources when Google Scholar item-level counts were not visible. ⁵⁶



Candidate measurable variables for a PhD

The most promising strategy is to begin with a **modular variable set** rather than trying to measure every construct in the literature. A good first-wave study could include six to eight text variables and six to eight reader variables, with transportation, identification, self-referencing, and persuasion outcomes as mediators/outcomes. The tables below give an initial candidate list. ⁵⁷

Candidate text features

Variable	Brief definition	Suggested operationalization
Verisimilitude	The degree to which events seem like they could happen in the world of the story	Human coding of plausibility; perceived-verisimilitude scale items; adaptation of realism items from Cho et al. and Busselle & Bilandzic. ⁵⁸
Narrative consistency	Internal coherence among events, motives, and story-world rules	Human coding rubric for contradictions/coherence; audience-rated consistency scale. ⁵⁹
Typicality	Whether characters/events feel representative of known real-world cases	Perceived typicality items from realism batteries; coder ratings of representativeness. ⁴²
Identifiable characters	The ease with which readers can individuate and mentally model protagonists	Code presence of stable name, traits, goals, backstory; audience identification precursor items. ⁴⁴
Imaginable plot	The extent to which events can be vividly simulated mentally	Audience-rated vividness/imaginability; coder ratings of scene concreteness and sensory detail. ⁶⁰
Point of view	Whether the story is told from first-person, close third-person, alternating, or omniscient perspective	Experimental manipulation or corpus coding of pronouns/focalization. ⁶¹
Emotional intensity	The extent of affectively consequential events and explicit emotional cues	Coder ratings of emotional peaks; sentiment/emotion lexicon scores; manipulation checks. ⁶²
Storyline complexity and causality	Density and clarity of causal links among events	Coder rubric for causal connectedness and plot closure; narrative graph measures if using corpora. ⁶³
Self-relevance cues in the narrative	Cues that invite “this could be me” processing	Coding for second-person language, everyday contexts, audience-matched details, or protagonist adaptation. ⁶⁴

Variable	Brief definition	Suggested operationalization
Engagement affordances	Features likely to support attention, presence, and emotional engagement	Narrative Engagement Scale subdimensions as downstream checks; code for suspense, conflict, pacing, cliffhangers. ⁶⁵

Candidate reader factors

Variable	Brief definition	Suggested operationalization
Transportability	Trait-like tendency to become transported by stories	Transportability or transportation short-form trait adaptation; items based on Mazzocco et al. and later transportation-scale work. ⁶⁶
Need for affect	Disposition to seek and value emotional experiences	Need for Affect Questionnaire, ideally with approach and avoidance subscales. ⁴⁷
Need for cognition	Disposition to enjoy effortful thought	Standard NFC scale; include possible interaction with medium or distraction. ⁴⁸
Prior knowledge or familiarity	Topic, genre, or lived-experience familiarity before exposure	Self-report familiarity index; prior-experience checklist; domain knowledge quiz. ⁶⁷
Trait empathy	Dispositional tendency to understand and share others' feelings	Interpersonal Reactivity Index or short empathy scales. ⁶⁸
Sensation seeking	Preference for novel, arousing experiences	Brief Sensation Seeking Scale or similar validated scale. ⁶⁹
Perceived protagonist similarity	Reader's subjective sense of being like the protagonist	Multi-item perceived similarity scale, separate from demographic match. ⁷⁰
Self-referencing tendency	Habitual tendency to relate incoming information to the self	State self-referencing after each narrative; trait self-focus/self-reference measures if needed. ⁷¹
Baseline attitudes and issue involvement	Preexisting stance toward the narrative topic	Pre-test attitude scales; issue involvement index. Especially important for persuasion-change designs. ⁷²
Attention	Degree of focused concentration during reception	Self-report attention/focus items, clickstream/reading-time proxies, or distraction manipulations. ⁷³

A practical first-pass measurement battery for a general PhD design would therefore be: **text side** = verisimilitude, consistency, identifiable characters, imaginable plot, point of view, emotional intensity; **reader side** = transportability, need for affect, need for cognition, prior familiarity, trait empathy, perceived

similarity; **process variables** = transportation, identification, self-referencing, emotional response, counterarguing; **outcomes** = beliefs, attitudes, intentions, and where possible, delayed outcomes. That design would align closely with the most-cited work while still being statistically manageable. 74

Open questions and limitations

A few limitations of the present synthesis should be explicit. First, citation counts are approximate snapshots from retrievable web sources on **2026-05-18**, and some counts came from Google Scholar snippets while others required fallback sources when item-level Google Scholar counts were not exposed. Second, a small number of classic articles exposed only partial abstract detail in retrievable snippets, so some summaries are more conceptually confident than statistically granular. Third, “reader individual differences” in this literature blur together three kinds of variables—stable traits, prior knowledge/familiarity, and reader-story fit variables such as perceived similarity—so your dissertation will benefit from defining that category sharply at the outset. 75

The strongest unresolved substantive question is not whether transportation matters—it clearly does—but **which combinations of text features and reader predispositions most reliably produce it across domains**. The field has strong evidence for realism, coherence, character identifiability, plot imaginability, transportability, need for affect, and perceived similarity, but the evidence is more mixed for simple demographic similarity, point-of-view effects in isolation, and broad demographic moderators such as age. That pattern suggests a fruitful dissertation strategy: test a parsimonious interaction model rather than a long list of independent main effects. 76

1 2 14 18 43 44 57 60 63 73 74 <https://openaccess.city.ac.uk/id/eprint/18870/1/Extended%20Transportation-Imagery%20Model%20CRO.pdf>
<https://openaccess.city.ac.uk/id/eprint/18870/1/Extended%20Transportation-Imagery%20Model%20CRO.pdf>

3 11 37 38 61 <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/0093650211408594>
<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/0093650211408594>

4 75 <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/mar.22011>
<https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/mar.22011>

5 24 25 26 <https://www.semanticscholar.org/paper/The-role-of-transportation-in-the-persuasiveness-of-Green-Brock/bc637900cf9d32410a0e0e7fd5fe675ad9626ea4>
<https://www.semanticscholar.org/paper/The-role-of-transportation-in-the-persuasiveness-of-Green-Brock/bc637900cf9d32410a0e0e7fd5fe675ad9626ea4>

6 9 27 33 34 <https://academic.oup.com/ct/article-abstract/18/3/407/4098715>
<https://academic.oup.com/ct/article-abstract/18/3/407/4098715>

7 29 30 67 https://scispace.com/papers/transportation-into-narrative-worlds-the-role-of-prior-29qiasguuu?citations_page=38
https://scispace.com/papers/transportation-into-narrative-worlds-the-role-of-prior-29qiasguuu?citations_page=38

8 <https://opus.bibliothek.uni-augsburg.de/opus4/files/39515/39515.pdf>
<https://opus.bibliothek.uni-augsburg.de/opus4/files/39515/39515.pdf>

10 35 65 <https://opus.bibliothek.uni-augsburg.de/opus4/files/39512/39512.pdf>
<https://opus.bibliothek.uni-augsburg.de/opus4/files/39512/39512.pdf>

12 39 40 64 <https://academic.oup.com/jcr/article/33/4/421/1790292>

<https://academic.oup.com/jcr/article/33/4/421/1790292>

13 41 42 58 59 76 <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/0093650212450585>

<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/0093650212450585>

15 45 46 66 72 <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/1948550610376600>

<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/1948550610376600>

16 47 62 [https://www.uni-wuerzburg.de/fileadmin/06020400/user_upload/Richter/](https://www.uni-wuerzburg.de/fileadmin/06020400/user_upload/Richter/Appel_Richter_inPress_2010.pdf)

[Appel_Richter_inPress_2010.pdf](https://www.uni-wuerzburg.de/fileadmin/06020400/user_upload/Richter/Appel_Richter_inPress_2010.pdf)

https://www.uni-wuerzburg.de/fileadmin/06020400/user_upload/Richter/Appel_Richter_inPress_2010.pdf

17 48 [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/263687355_Narrative_Persuasion_Transportation_and_the_Role_of_Need_for_Cognition_in_Online_Viewing_of_Fantastical_Films)

[263687355_Narrative_Persuasion_Transportation_and_the_Role_of_Need_for_Cognition_in_Online_Viewing_of_Fantastical_Films](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/263687355_Narrative_Persuasion_Transportation_and_the_Role_of_Need_for_Cognition_in_Online_Viewing_of_Fantastical_Films)

[https://www.researchgate.net/publication/](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/263687355_Narrative_Persuasion_Transportation_and_the_Role_of_Need_for_Cognition_in_Online_Viewing_of_Fantastical_Films)

[263687355_Narrative_Persuasion_Transportation_and_the_Role_of_Need_for_Cognition_in_Online_Viewing_of_Fantastical_Films](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/263687355_Narrative_Persuasion_Transportation_and_the_Role_of_Need_for_Cognition_in_Online_Viewing_of_Fantastical_Films)

19 49 71 <https://academic.oup.com/hcr/article-abstract/40/1/73/4093727>

<https://academic.oup.com/hcr/article-abstract/40/1/73/4093727>

20 51 [https://www.academia.edu/35120295/](https://www.academia.edu/35120295/Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist_Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist_Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_S](https://www.academia.edu/35120295/Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist_Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[https://www.academia.edu/35120295/](https://www.academia.edu/35120295/Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist_Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist_Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing](https://www.academia.edu/35120295/Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist_Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

21 52 53 [https://cris.iucc.ac.il/en/publications/does-character-similarity-increase-identification-and-](https://cris.iucc.ac.il/en/publications/does-character-similarity-increase-identification-and-persuasion/)

[persuasion/](https://cris.iucc.ac.il/en/publications/does-character-similarity-increase-identification-and-persuasion/)

<https://cris.iucc.ac.il/en/publications/does-character-similarity-increase-identification-and-persuasion/>

22 54 70 <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371%2Fjournal.pone.0215359>

<https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371%2Fjournal.pone.0215359>

23 55 68 69 <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1037/gpr0000130>

<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1037/gpr0000130>

28 [https://www.communicationcache.com/uploads/1/0/8/8/10887248/entertainment-](https://www.communicationcache.com/uploads/1/0/8/8/10887248/entertainment-education_and_elaboration_likelihood_-_understanding_the_process_of_narrative_persuasion.pdf)

[education_and_elaboration_likelihood_-_understanding_the_process_of_narrative_persuasion.pdf](https://www.communicationcache.com/uploads/1/0/8/8/10887248/entertainment-education_and_elaboration_likelihood_-_understanding_the_process_of_narrative_persuasion.pdf)

[https://www.communicationcache.com/uploads/1/0/8/8/10887248/entertainment-education_and_elaboration_likelihood_-_](https://www.communicationcache.com/uploads/1/0/8/8/10887248/entertainment-education_and_elaboration_likelihood_-_understanding_the_process_of_narrative_persuasion.pdf)

[_understanding_the_process_of_narrative_persuasion.pdf](https://www.communicationcache.com/uploads/1/0/8/8/10887248/entertainment-education_and_elaboration_likelihood_-_understanding_the_process_of_narrative_persuasion.pdf)

31 <https://opus.bibliothek.uni-augsburg.de/opus4/frontdoor/index/index/docId/39515>

<https://opus.bibliothek.uni-augsburg.de/opus4/frontdoor/index/index/docId/39515>

32 <https://d-nb.info/1307098401/34>

<https://d-nb.info/1307098401/34>

36 https://www.researchgate.net/publication/241682327_Measuring_Narrative_Engagement

https://www.researchgate.net/publication/241682327_Measuring_Narrative_Engagement

50 [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[https://www.researchgate.net/publication/](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

[Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/305313584_Narrator_Point_of_View_and_Persuasion_in_Health_Narratives_The_Role_of_Protagonist-Reader_Similarity_Identification_and_Self-Referencing)

⁵⁶ <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/11079236/>
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/11079236/>